technology, education, innovation, investment and security. Even traditional areas like energy have witnessed broader Indian participation. Not least, the Gulf also serves as a bridgehead for greater involvement with Africa.

To the south, the SAGAR outlook brings together our maritime neighbours in an integrated manner. Some countries like Sri Lanka and the Maldives overlap with the Neighbourhood First policy. But others today note the stronger focus and larger resources that India is prepared to devote. Our development partnership with Mauritius has emerged as an exemplar in this context. The underlying maritime cooperation has also become the basis for an emerging security conclave that encourages more cooperative thinking.

To the north, Connect Central Asia Policy is the last piece of the puzzle which forges more systemic linkages with culturally comfortable partners. The agenda here is much more about connectivity, de-radicalization and development. For many of these states, India offers options that strengthen their overall positioning.

Clearly, how smoothly India advances in its multiple quests depends on the nature of its ties with major powers. In certain cases, Europe being one, constituent segments of a collective also need to be engaged individually. Many of them have the ability to facilitate this process; some have the ability to obstruct as well. It is naturally our endeavour to continually create an optimal mix. And this cannot be done by always staying the middle course or ducking the difficult problems. Obviously, there is a strong case for both prudence and perseverance. But there is an even more powerful one for understanding which relationship serves our interest best on which issues. As a result, contemporary diplomacy looks far from linear, often ending up in apparent zigzags. But the real test of its effectiveness is whether it puts India ahead in the competitive game. And such periodic assessments, therefore, assume importance in both policy validation and course correction, where required.

An essential part of preparing for a global footprint is to expand the breadth of interactions. The truth is that a very large number of nations have been engaged very perfunctorily by India for many years now. Even today, there are countries that are receiving an Indian foreign minister for the first time in their history. Realizing this, our efforts in the last decade have been to find more efficient ways of conducting global diplomacy.